

STATE & VARNA SOCIETY IN THE AGE OF THE BUDDHA

PERIOD HORIZON AND SOURCE → FROM JANA TO TERRITORIAL → SECOND URBANISATION AS A → AGRARIAN BASE, IRON AND → STATE INSTITUTIONS AND DIFFERENTIATED → VARNA NORM AND SOCIAL

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g5 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00 PERIOD HORIZON AND SOURCE METHOD

PERIOD HORIZON AND SOURCE METHOD LATER VEDIC BACKGROUND C. 600-400 BCE CORE C. 600-200 BCE WIDER HORIZON AGRARIAN AND VARNA CHANGE NIKAYAS/VINAYA + JAINA TEXTS + DHARMASUTRAS/PANINI + ARCHAEOLOGY DO NOT MAKE UNLIKE SOURCES EXACTLY CONTEMPORARY.

NAMED SOURCE/SITE WHAT IT PROVES

LATER VEDIC BACKGROUND → c.

600-400 BCE CORE → c.

600-200 BCE WIDER HORIZON agrarian and varna change
Buddha-age polities textual redaction and urban growth

SOURCES: Nikayas/Vinaya + Jaina texts + Dharmasutras/Panini +
archaeology

Do not make unlike sources exactly contemporary.

CHRONOLOGY / PHASE

- LATER VEDIC BACKGROUND → c.
- 600-400 BCE CORE → c.

MATERIAL / INSTITUTION

- 600-200 BCE WIDER HORIZON agrarian and varna change Buddha-age polities textual redaction and urban growth
- SOURCES: Nikayas/Vinaya + Jaina texts + Dharmasutras/Panini + archaeology

IMPACT / LIMIT

- Do not make unlike sources exactly contemporary.
- METHOD: claim → named source/site → what it proves → transmission limit.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: METHOD: claim → named source/site → what it proves → transmission limit.

01

STAGE 01 FROM JANA TO TERRITORIAL STATE

FROM JANA TO TERRITORIAL STATE KIN COMMUNITY SETTLED TERRITORY LARGER COMPETING MAHAJANAPADAS MONARCHIES AND GANA-SANGHAS REVENUE + ARMY + FORTIFIED CENTRES + OFFICIALS + POLITICAL AUTHORITY BECAME MORE TERRITORIAL AND EXTRACTIVE.

CHANGE WAS REGIONALLY UNEVEN AND DID NOT ERASE CLAN

KIN COMMUNITY / JANA

settled territory / JANAPADA

larger competing MAHAJANAPADAS

monarchies and gana-sanghas

MECHANISMS: revenue + army + fortified centres + officials +
diplomacy

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- KIN COMMUNITY / JANA
- settled territory / JANAPADA
- larger competing MAHAJANAPADAS

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- monarchies and gana-sanghas
- MECHANISMS: revenue + army + fortified centres + officials + diplomacy
- RESULT: political authority became more territorial and extractive.

DEBATE / LEGACY

- LIMIT: change was regionally uneven and did not erase clan structures.
- TRAP: gana-sangha was restricted oligarchy, not modern democracy.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — RESULT: political authority became more territorial and extractive.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRAP: gana-sangha was restricted oligarchy, not modern democracy.

02

STAGE 02 SECOND URBANISATION AS A SYSTEM

SECOND URBANISATION AS A SYSTEM AGRARIAN SURPLUS SPECIALISED CRAFTS TOWNS STATE DEMAND <- TAXES, ARMIES, OFFICIALS <- MERCHANTS URBANISATION WAS A NETWORK OF PRODUCTION, POWER AND CIRCULATION. NBPW IS AN ASSOCIATED MATERIAL HORIZON, NOT THE SINGLE

AGRARIAN SURPLUS → SPECIALISED CRAFTS → EXCHANGE → TOWNS state demand <- taxes

armies, officials <- merchants and householders roads + rivers + coin use

Urbanisation was a network of production, power and circulation.

NBPW is an associated material horizon, not the single cause of towns.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- AGRARIAN SURPLUS → SPECIALISED CRAFTS → EXCHANGE → TOWNS state demand <- taxes,
- armies, officials <- merchants and householders roads + rivers + coin use

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- Urbanisation was a network of production, power and circulation.
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DEBATE / LEGACY

- AGRARIAN SURPLUS → SPECIALISED CRAFTS → EXCHANGE → TOWNS state demand <- taxes,
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ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: NBPW is an associated material horizon, not the single cause of towns.

03

STAGE 03 AGRARIAN BASE, IRON AND REVENUE

03

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- AGRARIAN SURPLUS → SPECIALISED CRAFTS → EXCHANGE → TOWNS state demand <- taxes,
- armies, officials <- merchants and householders roads + rivers + coin use

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- Urbanisation was a network of production, power and circulation.
- NBPW is an associated material horizon, not the single cause of towns.

DEBATE / LEGACY

- AGRARIAN SURPLUS → SPECIALISED CRAFTS → EXCHANGE → TOWNS state demand <- taxes,
- armies, officials <- merchants and householders roads + rivers + coin use

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: NBPW is an associated material horizon, not the single cause of towns.

04

STAGE 03

AGRARIAN BASE, IRON AND REVENUE

AGRARIAN BASE, IRON AND REVENUE

FOREST CLEARANCE + PLOUGH AGRICULTURE + LABOUR LARGER AND

TERRITORIAL COMPETITION

IRON ENABLED TOOLS AND WEAPONS BUT DID NOT MECHANICALLY

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- FOREST CLEARANCE + PLOUGH AGRICULTURE + LABOUR larger and more regular surplus shares, tribute,
- labour dues and market-related extraction treasury → officials → army → territorial competition

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- CAUTION: iron enabled tools and weapons but did not mechanically create states.
- FOREST CLEARANCE + PLOUGH AGRICULTURE + LABOUR larger and more regular surplus shares, tribute,

DEBATE / LEGACY

- labour dues and market-related extraction treasury → officials → army → territorial competition
- CAUTION: iron enabled tools and weapons but did not mechanically create states.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CAUTION: iron enabled tools and weapons but did not mechanically create states.

05

STAGE 04

STATE INSTITUTIONS AND DIFFERENTIATED OFFICES

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RULING LINEAGE MINISTERS AND MAHAMATTAS

REVENUE AND JUDICIAL FUNCTIONS ARMY AND COMMANDERS

COERCION AND DEFENCE VILLAGE HEADS

LOCAL MEDIATION AND COLLECTION ENVOYS AND ALLIANCES

INTERSTATE COMPETITION

OFFICE TERMS SHOW FUNCTIONAL DIFFERENTIATION, NOT A UNIFORM MAURYAN

RESOURCES + INFORMATION + COMPLIANCE, NOT TITLES ALONE.

RAJAN / RULING LINEAGE ministers and mahamattas → revenue and judicial functions army and commanders

coercion and defence village heads → local mediation and collection envoys and alliances → interstate

Office terms show functional differentiation, not a uniform Mauryan bureaucracy.

Capacity = resources + information + compliance, not titles alone.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- RAJAN / RULING LINEAGE ministers and mahamattas → revenue and judicial functions army and commanders →
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06

STAGE 05

VARNA NORM AND SOCIAL PRACTICE

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BRAHMANICAL NORM LIVED SOCIAL FIELD FOURFOLD RANKED VARNA OCCUPATIONS

VARNA ORGANISED CLAIMS TO HIERARCHY; IT DID NOT FULLY

NEITHER TIMELESS RIGIDITY NOR UNRESTRICTED MOBILITY IS EVIDENCE-SAFE.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

BRAHMANICAL NORM LIVED SOCIAL FIELD fourfold ranked varna occupations, jatis, clans and regions duty and ritual status wealth, power, mobility and exclusion prescriptive texts Buddhist/Jaina texts + archaeology

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

Varna organised claims to hierarchy; it did not fully describe every social relation. Neither timeless rigidity nor unrestricted mobility is evidence-safe.

DEBATE / LEGACY

BRAHMANICAL NORM LIVED SOCIAL FIELD fourfold ranked varna occupations, jatis, clans and regions duty and ritual status wealth, power, mobility and exclusion prescriptive texts Buddhist/Jaina texts + archaeology

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

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ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Neither timeless rigidity nor unrestricted mobility is evidence-safe.

06

STAGE 06

HOUSEHOLDERS, MERCHANTS, LABOUR AND DEPENDENCY

HOUSEHOLDERS, MERCHANTS, LABOUR AND DEPENDENCY

SUBSTANTIAL HOUSEHOLD HEAD

AGRARIAN AND SOCIAL AUTHORITY

WEALTHY MERCHANT-FINANCIER IN URBAN-COMMERCIAL NETWORKS

CULTIVATOR; CATEGORY CONTAINED UNEQUAL HOLDINGS AND DEPENDENCE

SPECIALISED PRODUCTION AND GUILD-LIKE ASSOCIATION

DEPENDENT AND UNFREE LABOUR CATEGORIES

OUTSIDE HOUSEHOLD IDEAL YET DEPENDENT ON LAY PATRONAGE

GAHAPATI: substantial household head / agrarian and social authority

SETTHI: wealthy merchant-financier in urban-commercial networks

KASSAKA: cultivator; category contained unequal holdings and dependence

KAMMIKAS / ARTISANS: specialised production and guild-like association

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- GAHAPATI: substantial household head / agrarian and social authority

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- KAMMIKAS / ARTISANS: specialised production and guild-like association

DEBATE / LEGACY

- Wealth could raise influence without automatically cancelling ritual hierarchy.

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06

STAGE 06

HOUSEHOLDERS, MERCHANTS, LABOUR AND DEPENDENCY

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POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

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KASSAKA: cultivator; category contained unequal holdings and dependence

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

KAMMIKAS / ARTISANS: specialised production and guild-like association

DASA-KAMMAKARA: dependent and unfree labour categories

RENUNCIANTS: outside household ideal yet dependent on lay patronage

DEBATE / LEGACY

Wealth could raise influence without automatically cancelling ritual hierarchy.

Use social terms with source and context; do not make them modern classes.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Use social terms with source and context; do not make them modern classes.

07

STAGE 07

WOMEN, HOUSEHOLD POWER AND EXCLUSION

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TEXTUAL NORMS

PATRILINY, MARRIAGE CONTROL AND GENDERED DUTIES

BUDDHIST/JAINA MATERIAL

NUNS, DONORS, HOUSEHOLDERS AND DEBATES OVER ADMISSION

MATERIAL SILENCE

ARCHAEOLOGY RARELY IDENTIFIES GENDER WITHOUT CONTEXT

AGENCY EXISTED WITHIN UNEQUAL INSTITUTIONS; ELITE WOMEN CANNOT STAND

SOURCE / MATERIAL

TEXTUAL NORMS: patriliney, marriage control and gendered duties

BUDDHIST/JAINA MATERIAL: nuns, donors, householders and debates over admission

METHOD / DEBATE

MATERIAL SILENCE: archaeology rarely identifies gender without context

Agency existed within unequal institutions; elite women cannot stand for all women.

HISTORICAL RESULT

Renunciation opened spaces but preserved hierarchy and dependence.

VERDICT: recover variation without inventing equality or total seclusion.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: recover variation without inventing equality or total seclusion.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: recover variation without inventing equality or total seclusion.

08

STAGE 08

SHRAMANA CHALLENGE AND SOCIAL RESPONSE

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RITUAL COST + URBAN CHANGE + SOCIAL MOBILITY +

BUDDHIST, JAINA, AJIVIKA AND OTHER RENUNCIANT CRITIQUES ETHICS, KARMA

SHRAMANA MOVEMENTS CHALLENGED HIERARCHY UNEVENLY, NOT ALL SOCIAL RANKING.

RITUAL COST + URBAN CHANGE + SOCIAL MOBILITY + SUFFERING

Buddhist, Jaina, Ajivika and other renunciant critiques ethics, karma, rebirth, non-injury, discipline and

new communities merchant and ruler patronage + monastic institutions + doctrinal competition

LIMIT: shramana movements challenged hierarchy unevenly, not all social ranking.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

RITUAL COST + URBAN CHANGE + SOCIAL MOBILITY + SUFFERING

Buddhist, Jaina, Ajivika and other renunciant critiques ethics, karma, rebirth, non-injury, discipline and

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

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DEBATE / LEGACY

RITUAL COST + URBAN CHANGE + SOCIAL MOBILITY + SUFFERING

Buddhist, Jaina, Ajivika and other renunciant critiques ethics, karma, rebirth, non-injury, discipline and

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LIMIT: shramana movements challenged hierarchy unevenly, not all social ranking.

09

STAGE 09

MATERIAL EVIDENCE: POTTERY, COINS, TOWNS AND ROUTES

MATERIAL EVIDENCE

POTTERY, COINS, TOWNS AND ROUTES

CONSUMPTION AND EARLY-HISTORIC SETTLEMENT HORIZON

DEFENCE, LABOUR MOBILISATION AND POLITICAL INVESTMENT

PUNCH-MARKED COINS

MONETISED EXCHANGE IN SELECTED CIRCUITS

CRAFT AREAS

SPECIALISED PRODUCTION AND URBAN DEMAND

SOURCE / MATERIAL	METHOD / DEBATE	HISTORICAL RESULT
NBPW → consumption and early-historic settlement horizon	CRAFT AREAS → specialised production and urban demand	No single marker proves a city, ruler, varna or religious community.
FORTIFICATIONS → defence, labour mobilisation and political investment	SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY → links villages, towns and political centres	Use convergence among artefact, layer, text and regional sequence.
PUNCH-MARKED COINS → monetised exchange in selected circuits	RIVERS/ROADS → movement of goods, armies, pilgrims and information	

SOURCE / MATERIAL

NBPW → consumption and early-historic settlement horizon

FORTIFICATIONS → defence, labour mobilisation and political investment

PUNCH-MARKED COINS → monetised exchange in selected circuits

METHOD / DEBATE

CRAFT AREAS → specialised production and urban demand

SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY → links villages, towns and political centres

RIVERS/ROADS → movement of goods, armies, pilgrims and information

HISTORICAL RESULT

No single marker proves a city, ruler, varna or religious community.

Use convergence among artefact, layer, text and regional sequence.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Use convergence among artefact, layer, text and regional sequence.

STATE & VARNA SOCIETY IN THE AGE OF THE BUDDHA • TILE 3/4 • same master rows 5412-8646 of 11352 • continues below

NBPW → consumption and early-historic settlement horizon	CRAFT AREAS → specialised production and urban demand	No single marker proves a city, ruler, varna or religious community.
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SOURCE / MATERIAL - NBPW → consumption and early-historic settlement horizon - FORTIFICATIONS → defence, labour mobilisation and political investment - PUNCH-MARKED COINS → monetised exchange in selected circuits	METHOD / DEBATE - CRAFT AREAS → specialised production and urban demand - SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY → links villages, towns and political centres - RIVERS/ROADS → movement of goods, armies, pilgrims and information	HISTORICAL RESULT - No single marker proves a city, ruler, varna or religious community. - Use convergence among artefact, layer, text and regional sequence.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Use convergence among artefact, layer, text and regional sequence.		

10

STAGE 10

CHANGE AND CONTINUITY ACROSS POLITY AND SOCIETY

CHANGE AND CONTINUITY ACROSS POLITY AND SOCIETY

LARGER STATES

COIN USE

RENUNCIANT INSTITUTIONS

AGRARIAN HOUSEHOLD

RITUAL HIERARCHY

LOCAL COMMUNITIES

MONARCHY VS GANA

CONTINUITY: kinship	agrarian household	ritual hierarchy	local communities
TENSION: monarchy vs gana	wealth vs status	norm vs practice	

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- CHANGE: larger states
- coin use
- renunciant institutions
- CONTINUITY: kinship
- agrarian household

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- ritual hierarchy
- local communities
- TENSION: monarchy vs gana
- wealth vs status
- norm vs practice

DEBATE / LEGACY

- REGIONALITY: Ganga plains != north-west != Deccan trajectories
- The Buddha age was accelerated restructuring, not a total social revolution.
- Best answers connect political capacity, economy, hierarchy and ethical critique.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Best answers connect political capacity, economy, hierarchy and ethical critique.

11

STAGE 11

EXAMINER-READY BUDDHA-AGE ANSWER SPINE

EXAMINER-READY BUDDHA-AGE ANSWER SPINE

DEFINE THE SIXTH-FIFTH CENTURY BCE CORE WITHIN A WIDER

BODY 1

SOURCE HIERARCHY AND CHRONOLOGY CAUTION

BODY 2

TERRITORIAL STATES, INSTITUTIONS AND AGRARIAN EXTRACTION

BODY 3

TOWNS, TRADE, HOUSEHOLDERS, ARTISANS AND LABOUR

INTRO: define the sixth-fifth century BCE core within a wider early-historic range.

BODY 1: source hierarchy and chronology caution

BODY 2: territorial states, institutions and agrarian extraction

BODY 3: towns, trade, householders, artisans and labour

BODY 4: varna norm, lived hierarchy, gender and shramana critique

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

INTRO: define the sixth-fifth century BCE core within a wider early-historic range.

BODY 1: source hierarchy and chronology caution

BODY 2: territorial states, institutions and agrarian extraction

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

BODY 3: towns, trade, householders, artisans and labour

BODY 4: varna norm, lived hierarchy, gender and shramana critique

COUNTER: regional variation, composite texts and material-evidence limits

DEBATE / LEGACY

CONCLUSION: state, economy and society changed together but unevenly.

WRITE: process → named evidence → social effect → qualification.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: process → named evidence → social effect → qualification.

E

EXTRA

SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT

1. SNAPSHOT & CORE IDEA

2. KEY CLASSIFICATION

3. STUDY LINKS

4. MUST-KNOW FACTS (PRELIMS)

5. UPSC TRAPS

6. CURRENT LINK

7. MAINS ANGLES

OPTIONAL SOURCE DEPTH

• Mini-timeline

• 1. Snapshot & core idea

• 2. Key classification / data

• 3. Study links

ADVANCED DEBATE

• 4. Must-Know Facts (Prelims)

• 5. UPSC Traps

• 6. Current link

• 7. Mains angles

LEGACY / NUANCE

• The political map contained monarchical states (rajyas), oligarchic states (ganas/sanghas), and tribal principalities .

• The 16 great states were not identical; they differed in size, constitution, economy and military capacity.

• The period saw land and agrarian expansion, early historic cities, crafts, guilds, money and new social elites.

• Renunciant traditions emerged in a society where householders, traders, setthis and gahapatis became increasingly visible.

OPTIONAL STATUS —

This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.